

D564

Theories of Personality

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A college student who works part-time at a bookstore wants to skip a required exam review to go to a concert, feels intense guilt at the thought, and finally decides to attend the review and buy concert tickets for next month. Her roommate owns two cats. In psychoanalytic terms, which structure produced the final plan?

- A. The id.
- B. The conscious mind, since all decisions are fully conscious.
- C. The superego.
- D. The ego.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A manager who recently moved into a larger office is furious at his boss after a harsh review. He says nothing at work, then goes home and yells at his teenage son for leaving shoes by the door. The son plays varsity tennis. Which defense mechanism is this?

- A. Displacement.
- B. Projection.
- C. Rationalization.
- D. Reaction formation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A person who strongly dislikes a coworker becomes excessively friendly and complimentary toward her. Which defense mechanism fits, and what is the direction of the feeling?

- A. Displacement: the dislike is moved to a new target.
- B. Reaction formation: the true feeling is expressed as its opposite.
- C. Sublimation, since any friendly behavior is a healthy defense.
- D. Projection: the person believes the coworker dislikes her.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

An employee who drives a restored pickup truck keeps a detailed planner, meets every deadline, and double-checks her reports. She is quiet in meetings and prefers working alone. Which Big Five trait is most clearly high for her?

- A. Conscientiousness.
- B. Introversion, which is a Big Five trait of its own.
- C. Extraversion.
- D. Agreeableness.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A 16-year-old who is on the school robotics team is told by his parents, who both work as accountants, that they are proud of him only when he earns straight A's. He now feels like a failure when he gets a B. In person-centered theory, what has he developed?

- A. Self-actualization.
- B. Unconditional positive regard.
- C. A strong superego.
- D. Conditions of worth, creating incongruence between his real and ideal self.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A nursing student who grew up in a small coastal town is confident she can start an IV because she has done it successfully in the lab many times, though she describes herself as generally shy and unsure in social settings. Which concept best describes her confidence about the IV?

- A. An internal locus of control.
- B. Self-esteem.
- C. Self-efficacy.
- D. Low self-efficacy, since shyness lowers confidence in every task.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which example best illustrates reciprocal determinism?

- A.** A dog salivates at the sound of a can opener.
- B.** A child's temperament is fixed at birth and determines all later behavior.
- C.** A confident student joins a study group, the group's support raises her grades, and better grades raise her confidence further.
- D.** The environment alone shapes behavior, with no role for beliefs.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

A popular science podcast host who studied biology reports that a large twin study found the heritability of extraversion to be about 50%. A listener concludes, "So half of my outgoing personality came from my genes." What is wrong with this conclusion?

- A.** Heritability describes how much of the differences among people in a group relate to genes, not how much of one person's trait is genetic.
- B.** The figure must be wrong because personality is entirely learned.
- C.** Nothing; heritability tells exactly what share of each person's trait is genetic.
- D.** The podcast host is not a psychologist, so the result cannot be trusted.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

If the heritability of a trait is 40% in a population, what share of the variation among people is linked to non-genetic factors, and what does that include?

- A.** 40%, the same as the heritability.
- B.** About 60%, including shared and non-shared environment plus measurement error.
- C.** 0%, because heritability sets the trait.
- D.** About 60% of each individual's personality.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A researcher at a university with a large psychology department surveys 2,000 adults and finds that people high in conscientiousness earn higher incomes ($r = .35$). The survey was completed online in about 12 minutes. What can she conclude?

- A. The results are unreliable because the survey took only 12 minutes.
- B. Conscientiousness causes higher income.
- C. Conscientiousness and income are positively related, but the study cannot show that one causes the other.
- D. The finding is meaningless because $r = .35$ is below $.50$.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A personality test gives people nearly the same score each time they take it, but its scores do not predict any behavior the test claims to measure. How should the test be described?

- A. Neither, since a test cannot be reliable without being valid.
- B. Valid but not reliable.
- C. Both reliable and valid, since consistency proves accuracy.
- D. Reliable but not valid.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

Researchers ask adults from two countries, both with high literacy rates, to complete the sentence “I am ...” twenty times. In one country, most answers list roles such as “a daughter” and “a member of my village council.” The study was funded by an international foundation. What does this pattern most likely reflect?

- A. Low self-esteem among those respondents.
- B. An interdependent self-construal common in collectivistic cultures.
- C. An independent self-construal common in individualistic cultures.
- D. Proof that every person in that country thinks the same way.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A college student ~~who works part time at a bookstore~~ wants to skip a required exam review to go to a concert, feels intense guilt at the thought, and finally decides to attend the review and buy concert tickets for next month. ~~Her roommate owns two cats.~~ In psychoanalytic terms, which structure produced the final plan?

Target word: which structure made the compromise **Decides:** A realistic compromise between urge and guilt.

A	Confusion set	The id is the urge to go to the concert now.
B	Absolute language	The theory holds that much of the conflict operates unconsciously.
C	Adjacent category	The superego produced the guilt, not the compromise.
D	Correct	The ego balances the id's urge and the superego's guilt against reality.

2. Answer A Concept 2

A manager ~~who recently moved into a larger office~~ is furious at his boss after a harsh review. He says nothing at work, then goes home and yells at his teenage son for leaving shoes by the door. ~~The son plays varsity tennis.~~ Which defense mechanism is this?

Target word: defense mechanism **Decides:** The anger is redirected to a safer target.

A	Correct	Anger at the boss is moved onto a less threatening target.
B	Confusion set	Projection attributes his own feelings to someone else, such as claiming his son is angry at him.
C	Adjacent category	Rationalization is an excuse; nothing here is a justification.
D	Inverted operation	That would mean showing the opposite feeling, such as excessive praise for the boss.

3. Answer B Concept 2 • transfer

A person who strongly dislikes a coworker becomes excessively friendly and complimentary toward her. Which defense mechanism fits, and what is the direction of the feeling?

Target word: mechanism from a reversed feeling **Decides:** The expressed feeling is the opposite of the real one.

A	Confusion set	The target did not change; the feeling reversed.
B	Correct	Dislike becomes exaggerated friendliness.
C	Absolute language	Sublimation channels impulses into productive activity; exaggerated friendliness masking hostility is reaction formation.
D	Adjacent category	Nothing is attributed to the coworker.

4. Answer A Concept 3

An employee ~~who drives a restored pickup truck~~ keeps a detailed planner, meets every deadline, and double-checks her reports. ~~She is quiet in meetings and prefers working alone.~~ Which Big Five trait is most clearly high for her?

Target word: which trait is high **Decides:** Organized, dependable, and careful behavior.

A	Correct	Planning, reliability, and carefulness define conscientiousness.
B	Camouflage	Answers the quiet-in-meetings detail; introversion is the low end of extraversion, not a separate trait.
C	Inverted operation	Her quiet preference points to low extraversion.
D	Confusion set	Agreeableness is about warmth and cooperation, not organization.

5. Answer D Concept 4

A 16-year-old ~~who is on the school robotics team~~ is told by his parents, ~~who both work as accountants,~~ that they are proud of him only when he earns straight A's. He now feels like a failure when he gets a B. In person-centered theory, what has he developed?

Target word: result of conditional regard **Decides:** Acceptance tied to meeting a condition.

A	Adjacent category	Conditions of worth block, rather than produce, self-actualization.
B	Inverted operation	His parents' approval has conditions—the opposite.
C	Confusion set	A psychoanalytic term, not the person-centered explanation.
D	Correct	Conditional approval teaches him he is worthy only when he meets standards.

6. Answer C Concept 5

A nursing student ~~who grew up in a small coastal town~~ is confident she can start an IV because she has done it successfully in the lab many times, though she describes herself as generally shy and unsure in social settings. Which concept best describes her confidence about the IV?

Target word: task-specific belief **Decides:** Confidence about one specific skill based on past success.

A	Adjacent category	Locus of control is about whether outcomes depend on oneself in general, not confidence in a skill.
B	Confusion set	Self-esteem is overall self-worth; hers seems low while her IV confidence is high.
C	Correct	Belief in one's ability to succeed at a specific task, built by mastery experiences.
D	Absolute language	Self-efficacy is task-specific; social shyness does not set her IV confidence.

7. Answer C Concept 5 • transfer

Which example best illustrates reciprocal determinism?

Target word: identify the concept from an example — reverse direction **Decides:** Person, behavior, and environment influence one another.

A	Confusion set	Classical conditioning, a learning process without the person-environment exchange.
B	Adjacent category	A biological, one-way account, not mutual influence.
C	Correct	Personal factors, behavior, and environment each shape the others.
D	Dropped element	Drops the personal-factor side of the triangle.

8. Answer A Concept 6

A ~~popular science podcast host who studied biology~~ reports that a large twin study found the heritability of extraversion to be about 50%. A listener concludes, "So half of my outgoing personality came from my genes." What is wrong with this conclusion?

Target word: what heritability means **Decides:** Heritability describes variation across a population.

A	Correct	It is a population statistic, not an individual split.
B	Absolute language	Twin research consistently shows genetic and environmental contributions.
C	Inverted operation	Applies a group statistic to one individual.
D	Camouflage	The host's background does not change what heritability means.

9. Answer B Concept 6 · transfer

If the heritability of a trait is 40% in a population, what share of the variation among people is linked to non-genetic factors, and what does that include?

Target word: solve for the non-genetic share **Decides:** $100\% - 40\% = 60\%$.

A	Wrong stem number	Repeats the given figure.
B	Correct	The remainder after heritability covers environment and error.
C	Absolute language	Heritability leaves the remaining variation to other sources.
D	Dropped element	Right number, but drops the population frame and applies it to one person.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A researcher ~~at a university with a large psychology department~~ surveys 2,000 adults and finds that people high in conscientiousness earn higher incomes ($r = .35$). ~~The survey was completed online in about 12 minutes.~~ What can she conclude?

Target word: what a correlation shows **Decides:** Correlational design.

A	Camouflage	Survey length does not determine reliability; the design limits causal claims.
B	Inverted operation	Draws a causal conclusion from correlational data.
C	Correct	Correlation shows association; a third variable or reverse direction is possible.
D	Absolute language	A moderate correlation in a large sample is meaningful.

11. Answer D Concept 7 · transfer

A personality test gives people nearly the same score each time they take it, but its scores do not predict any behavior the test claims to measure. How should the test be described?

Target word: reliable vs. valid **Decides:** Consistent scores that fail to measure the intended construct.

A	Adjacent category	The reverse is true: validity requires reliability, but not the other way around.
B	Inverted operation	Reverses the two terms.
C	Confusion set	A consistent test can consistently measure the wrong thing.
D	Correct	Consistency is reliability; failing to measure the target is poor validity.

12. Answer B Concept 8

Researchers ask adults from two countries, ~~both with high literacy rates~~, to complete the sentence “I am ...” twenty times. In one country, most answers list roles such as “a daughter” and “a member of my village council.” ~~The study was funded by an international foundation.~~ What does this pattern most likely reflect?

Target word: self-construal type **Decides:** Self described through relationships and roles.

A	Adjacent category	Describing roles reflects cultural framing, not lower self-worth.
B	Correct	Defining the self by roles and relationships reflects interdependence.
C	Inverted operation	Independent self-descriptions list personal traits, such as “I am creative.”
D	Absolute language	Cultural tendencies describe averages; individuals vary.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	2	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	7	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Psychoanalytic structure of personality	In psychoanalytic theory the id seeks immediate pleasure, the superego holds moral standards, and the ego mediates between them and reality; much of this conflict is unconscious.	Equating the ego with arrogance or the superego with the conscious mind.	An urge, a moral voice, and a realistic compromise in the same scenario.
2	Defense mechanisms	Projection attributes one's own unacceptable feelings to others; displacement redirects feelings to a safer target; reaction formation expresses the opposite of the true feeling; rationalization offers a plausible excuse.	Mixing up projection and displacement because both move a feeling.	Who or what receives the feeling, and whether it is reversed.
3	The Big Five traits	Openness, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Neuroticism are broad, fairly stable dimensions; each person falls somewhere along each continuum.	Treating traits as types (you are or are not an extravert) or confusing agreeableness with extraversion.	Descriptions of organized, curious, sociable, cooperative, or anxious behavior.
4	Humanistic theory	Person-centered theory holds that growth toward self-actualization needs unconditional positive regard; conditions of worth create incongruence between the real and ideal self.	Confusing unconditional positive regard with approving of every behavior.	Love or acceptance that depends on meeting conditions.
5	Social-cognitive theory	Behavior, personal factors (such as self-efficacy and expectancies), and environment influence one another (reciprocal determinism); self-efficacy is belief in one's ability to succeed at a specific task.	Equating self-efficacy with general self-esteem.	Confidence about a particular task, or a person shaping and being shaped by a setting.
6	Heritability is a population statistic	Heritability estimates (often about 40–50% for major traits in twin studies) describe how much of the variation in a group is linked to genetic differences, not how much of one person's trait is genetic.	Saying half of an individual's personality comes from genes.	A heritability percentage applied to one person.
7	Correlation vs. experiment; reliability vs. validity	Correlational studies show association, not cause; only experiments with random assignment test cause. Reliability is consistency; validity is measuring what it claims to measure.	Inferring cause from a strong correlation, or calling a consistent test valid.	"Linked to," "predicts," or a test that gives the same score every time.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Culture and self-construal	Individualistic cultures tend to foster an independent self defined by personal traits; collectivistic cultures tend to foster an interdependent self defined by relationships and roles.	Treating one culture's trait descriptions as universal, or stereotyping every individual by culture.	Self-descriptions that list traits vs. roles and relationships.

Course scope (public description): Theories of Personality describes the concepts and assumptions of significant theories of personality. The course assesses the strengths and weaknesses of each major personality theory, describes and defines the research methodology frequently used by psychologists in the study of personality, and identifies the contributions of theory and empirical research to our contemporary understanding of personality. Cultural impacts on personality are also discussed. There are no prerequisites for this course.